

The Practitioner's Chemistry

Carrier oils, essential oil caution, and the wax chemistry behind a safe, effective treatment

Learning Objectives

- Choose an appropriate carrier oil for a client's skin type and the technique being used
- Explain correct essential oil dilution and name the key safety cautions
- Explain phototoxicity and which common essential oils carry this risk
- Explain the difference between hard and soft wax and when each is used safely

Carrier oils: the base every technique depends on

A carrier oil dilutes essential oils to a safe concentration and provides the glide a massage stroke depends on. Common choices include sweet almond oil (light, widely tolerated), coconut oil (deeply moisturising, solidifies in cooler rooms), grapeseed oil (very light, suits oily-prone skin), and jojoba oil (structurally similar to skin's own sebum, suits sensitive skin well). Match the carrier to the client's skin type from Course I's principles, and always patch test on a new client, particularly one disclosing any known allergies.

Essential oils: real effects, real cautions

Essential oils are highly concentrated plant extracts and must never be applied undiluted directly to skin. Standard professional dilution is typically 2–3% essential oil in a carrier oil for adult body massage — roughly 12–18 drops per 30ml of carrier oil, adjusted down further for sensitive skin, pregnancy, or facial application.

- **Lavender** — widely used for its calming association; low general irritation risk at correct dilution.

- **Peppermint** — cooling and often used for muscular tension; avoid near the eyes and on very young children.
- **Eucalyptus** — used for its clearing, invigorating scent; avoid on children under ten and during pregnancy without guidance.
- **Clary sage and rosemary** — generally avoided during pregnancy due to their traditional association with uterine stimulation; confirm current guidance and always err toward caution.

Phototoxicity: the citrus caution

Several citrus essential oils — bergamot in particular, along with some cold-pressed lemon and lime oils — contain compounds that react with UV light to cause phototoxic burns or pigmentation changes on skin exposed to sun after application. Advise any client receiving a treatment with these oils to avoid direct sun exposure on treated skin for at least twelve to twenty-four hours afterward, and consider avoiding them entirely for a client scheduled for outdoor activity immediately following her appointment.

◆ Figure 4.1 · Hard Wax vs. Soft Wax

<i>Hard Wax</i> no strip · hardens, lifts off itself	<i>Soft Wax</i> requires cloth/paper strip to remove
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Hard wax generally suits smaller, more sensitive areas; soft wax covers larger areas more efficiently.

Hard wax versus soft wax

Hard wax is applied thickly, allowed to harden, and removed without a strip by lifting an edge and pulling it away from itself — it grips hair more than skin, making it generally gentler for smaller, more sensitive areas like the face and bikini line. Soft wax is applied in a thin layer and removed using a cloth or paper strip pressed on top — more efficient for larger areas like legs and arms, but grips skin more directly, making correct technique and skin tension more important to avoid excess irritation or bruising.

Wax temperature: the burn risk that is entirely preventable

Wax that is too hot causes genuine burns, and wax that is too cool will not adhere or release properly, tearing skin on removal. Always test wax temperature on your own inner wrist before applying it to a client — every single time, regardless of how routine the appointment feels — never assume a warmer that "usually runs fine" is behaving the same way today.

Key Terms

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[object Object]

1

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2

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Practical Activity · The Dilution Practice

Calculate the correct number of essential oil drops for a 2% dilution in 30ml of carrier oil. Prepare the blend and test the wax-temperature check on your own wrist before an instructor or partner reviews your process. **Bring your calculations to your next live session.**